

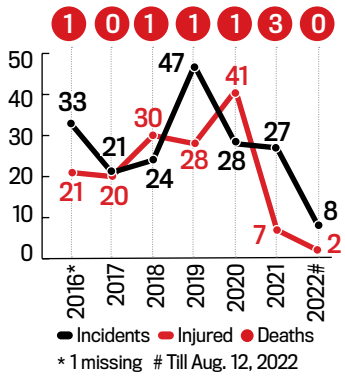
LOGJAM Timber seized from smugglers stocked at the Lateri forest depot

Photographs by MUJEEB FARUQUI

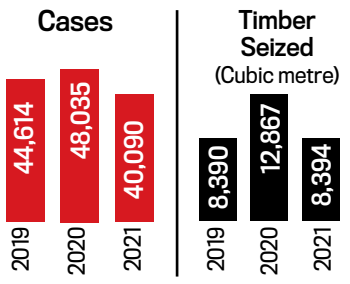
FOREST UNREST

Rampant felling triggers clash between guards and smugglers

ATTACKS ON MP'S FOREST DEPARTMENT STAFF



CASES OF ILLEGAL FELLING AND TIMBER SEIZURE



POACHERS/ SMUGGLERS KILLED, 2022

MAY	AUG
Guna	*Vidisha*
3*	1#

*Shot dead by the police where poachers had earlier killed three of their colleagues
** Tribal man, allegedly a timber smuggler, gunned down by forest officials

Graphic by ASIT ROY

claims they were pelted with rocks and hence had to fire in self-defence, the smugglers allege that they were ambushed and fired on. Chain Singh, 32, one of the smugglers, died on the spot, and five others, three of them his brothers and two cousins, were injured.

Unaware of the death, the forest department team returned to Lateri later at night. Around 12 am, the injured arrived at the police station with Chain's body and filed a complaint.

All hell broke loose when the accused were found to be members of the Bhil community. A case of murder was registered against Nirmal Ahirwar, the deputy ranger of the Kotra chowki under whose jurisdiction Khattyapura falls, besides other unknown persons. All six personnel who were there that night, including Vinod Singh, are absconding while Ahirwar, denied bail by the sessions court, is in jail. The next day, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, even before announcing a probe, ordered a compensation of Rs 25 lakh for the deceased and Rs 5 lakh each for the three injured brothers. After the murder case was filed against Ahirwar, the police registered a case under the relatively weak Section 353 of the IPC against the timber smugglers. The forest department also filed a POR or preliminary offence report—their equivalent of an FIR—against unknown smugglers.

Clearly, the BJP, which has been pursuing a 'tribal agenda' nationally, was on the defensive, especially since the opposition Congress accused the ruling party of being anti-tribal after the firing. The divisional forest officer has been transferred and the government has ordered a probe by a single-member commission of a retired high court judge. While politics took over the incident, the core issue—timber smuggling—has been brushed aside both by the BJP and the Congress.

MP has some of the best teak in the world, which continue to be sought-after in the furniture industry. The government controls all trade in the precious wood since it is a nationalised commodity. Officially priced at Rs 45,000 per cubic metre, it is sold for as little as Rs 5,000 by smugglers. While the state has been grappling with the issue of illegal felling for years, western MP is worst affected. Large areas have been wiped clean of teak trees in the districts of Jhabua, Alirajpur, Khandwa and even Betul